First Inaugural Address

President Barack Obama · January 20, 2009

Source: Obama Presidential Library, obamalibrary.gov; National Archives, archives.gov.

Obama took office as the first Black president of the United States, in the middle of the Great Recession — the worst economic crisis since the Great Depression — and with two active wars in Iraq and Afghanistan. The address blended a frank account of the country's problems with a call to civic responsibility. The crowd on the National Mall (estimated at 1.8 million) was the largest for any inauguration in U.S. history.

Connect: Obama's response to the 2008 crash echoes FDR's response to 1929 (Class 45). Compare the scale of the interventions. Who did each help most?

Key Passages

The crisis

> That we are in the midst of crisis is now well understood. Our nation is at war, against a far-reaching network of violence and hatred. Our economy is badly weakened, a consequence of greed and irresponsibility on the part of some, but also our collective failure to make hard choices and to prepare the nation for a new age. Homes have been lost; jobs shed; businesses shuttered.

On the nation's diversity

> For we know that our patchwork heritage is a strength, not a weakness. We are a nation of Christians and Muslims, Jews and Hindus — and non-believers. We are shaped by every language and culture, drawn from every end of this Earth; and because we have tasted the bitter swill of civil war and segregation, and emerged from that dark chapter stronger and more united, we cannot help but believe that the old hatreds shall someday pass.

On responsibility

> What is required of us now is a new era of responsibility — a recognition, on the part of every American, that we have duties to ourselves, our nation, and the world.

HAPP Analysis

Model answers fill the first three rows. Use them to explain the author's Purpose in the last row.

HAPP Element	Your Analysis
Historical Context *What was happening when this was written?*	The Great Recession after the 2008 financial crisis, ongoing wars in Iraq and Afghanistan, and a historic election.
Intended Audience *Who was the source written for?*	The American public, the crowd on the National Mall, and a worldwide audience.
Point of View *Whose perspective? Whose is missing?*	Barack Obama, the first Black president and a Democrat, who called for civic responsibility and an active government response to the crisis.

HAPP Element	Your Analysis
Purpose *What did the author want to accomplish?*	

Analysis Prompts

1. LEQ Historical Reasoning — Comparison (1 pt): Compare Obama's First Inaugural with FDR's First Inaugural (1933). What's similar in tone, scope, and political ask?

2. Identify ONE specific policy response Obama's administration made to the financial crisis.

3. How does the address use American history (Civil War, civil rights) to frame the present moment?